

FEMALE LEADERS IN SOUTH ASIA: THE IMPACT OF FEUDALISM AND RELIGIOUS FUNDAMENTALISM

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Patriarchy is at the core of virtually all feudal and religious fundamentalist traditions. There have been a few matriarchal societies in centuries past, and some features of matriarchy persist in a few societies that have become, in recent centuries, less and less matriarchal. The scriptures of nearly all major religions appear to lend legitimacy, in larger or smaller measure, to some forms of gender-based disparity. That many liberal scholars and theologians feel the need to engage in feminist reinterpretation of traditions and scriptures underscores the ubiquity of patriarchy in what they are seeking to reinterpret.

Throughout history, the proportion of women who have risen to be major leaders of politics, societies and religious communities has been small, in South Asia as elsewhere. Given the close links between patriarchy, feudalism and religious fundamentalism, it may seem reasonable to assume that the emergence of women leaders would be more difficult in societies immersed in feudal and religious fundamentalist traditions than in modern liberal democracies. In fact, many eminent scholars have pointed to the sudden emergence of women leaders at the apex in Sri Lanka, India, Pakistan and Bangladesh as evidence of emancipation and lack of gender prejudice in those countries and in that region. But is this what the facts reveal?

In Sri Lanka on the assassination of the Prime Minister S.W.R.D. Bandaranaike in 1959, his widow Sirimavo Bandaranaike, who had neither been politically active nor held any significant political office previously, was acclaimed leader of the ruling party and became the world's first female prime minister. She repeatedly claimed that her task as prime minister was to carry out the policies of her 'late husband'. She consolidated her political grip, continued as the unchallenged leader of her party, and was prime minister whenever that party was elected to power till she handed over the reins to her daughter Chandrika Bandaranaike Kumaratunge, herself widow of the assassinated charismatic political leader Vijaya Kumaratunge. In 1994 Chandrika became prime minister, and went on to be the country's first female executive president few months later.

Curiously, her main opponent in that presidential election was another widow, Srima Dissanayake, nominated in place of the assassinated Gamini Dissanayake. Chandrika, too, consolidated her political position and held office till the completion of her second term as president in 2005. Both mother and daughter were charismatic political leaders, whose rise to the top was very sudden. They enjoyed the support of very large numbers of female voters, but the percentage of female Members of Parliament (MPs) remained abysmally low (of the order of 5%) before, throughout their tenures of office, and after. Neither of them appeared to have been particularly interested in advancing female political representation or other feminist concerns. There are no reservations for women in the Sri Lankan Parliament, but there are moves to legislate for such reservations in local government.

In India, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru was succeeded by Lal Bahadur Shastri who, in turn, was succeeded by Indira Gandhi, daughter of Jawaharlal Nehru. Unlike Sirimavo Bandaranaike, Indira Gandhi has been deeply immersed in political issues from a very young age. She too consolidated her party and national leadership but was assassinated in 1984, she was succeeded by her son Rajiv Gandhi. Later, he was assassinated. In due course his widow Sonia Gandhi (from Italy) became party leader and was offered the office of prime minister which she declined. She remains the most charismatic leader of her party. Neither Sonia, nor Indira Gandhi before her, had been associated with advancing women's political representation or other feminist issues.

There are no reservations for women in the Indian Parliament and the proportion of women elected has always been 10% or less. That the proportion of women in the Indian Parliament is about double that in the Sri Lankan Parliament may be due primarily to the history of massive involvement of women, young and old, in the Gandhian social and political movements leading to independence. But 10% is not adequate. The major Indian political parties have agreed to a female political representation level of at least 33%, and this is provided for in respect of local government in terms of the Constitutional Amendment of 1992. Attempts to amend

the constitution to provide for quotas in Parliament have not yet succeeded despite agreement in principle by all the major parties. This remains a live issue.

In Pakistan, too, large numbers of women of diverse age groups were involved in the independence movement as well as in the agitation for partition (i.e. creation of Pakistan). Mohammad Ali Jinnah would often have his sister Fatima Jinnah sit with him at public meetings, before and after independence, despite repeated protests from orthodox religious leaders who held that women should not be active in politics nor hold high office in a Muslim country. In 1958 Field Marshal Ayub Khan captured power and went on to establish a new constitution in 1962, replacing the 1956 Constitution which had provided for dual voting rights for women – for the general seats open to men and women as well as for a few seats reserved for women. The imposed 1962 Constitution abolished direct elections to the presidency and to Parliament, and substituted indirect elections by an Electoral College based on local bodies. This effectively permitted manipulation by the incumbent president/dictator. In any case, it was mostly men who would be in the Electoral College. Thus, only six women were elected to Parliament under that Constitution.

Fatima Jinnah dared to contest the field marshal position in the 1965 presidential election. Her candidature generated unprecedented enthusiasm, particularly among women. Even the orthodox religious parties including the very powerful Jamaat-e-Islami, which had repeatedly declared that a woman could not hold high political office, supported her candidature. However Field Marshal Ayub Khan manipulated the Electoral College to secure his re-election, though it was clear that the majority of the voters backed Fatima Jinnah.

Women and students continued to play a major role in the agitation for democracy. In the parliamentary elections of 1970, there was over whelming support in West Pakistan for the Pakistan People's Party led by Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, and in East Pakistan for the Awami League led by Mujibur Rahman. Denied the office of prime minister despite winning the Parliamentary majority, Mujibur Rahman led a revolt and East Pakistan seceded to form Bangladesh. In the course of time Bhutto was dislodged and executed and his family fled the country. His daughter Benazir Bhutto returned to lead her father's party and to contest the 1988 elections at which she swept the polls and became prime minister. She was again expelled from the country but returned to contest and win the 1993 parliamentary elections. The military has been very powerful in Pakistan, and military dictators most difficult to

dislodge. It looked as if it was Benazir Bhutto who could succeed in doing it. In due course she returned again to contest parliamentary elections and generated much popular enthusiasm, but was assassinated on the eve of the elections in January 2008. Her party went on to win and her widower Asif Ali Zardari is now the party leader and president.

Despite women playing decisive roles in several national and regional elections the number of female MPs in Pakistan never reached double figures pre-2002, nor even during or in the immediate wake of the campaign led by Fatima Jinnah in 1965 or those led by Benazir Bhutto in 1988 and 1993. However there have been some remarkable individual successes. Nasim Wali Khan, widow of Wali Khan and daughter in law of Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan, was elected as leader of the opposition of the remote ultra-feudal North-West Frontier Province bordering Afghanistan and, even more incredibly, an Irish woman was elected as a member of the National Assembly from another remote region, Baluchistan. The feudal factor in one case, and the related colonial factor in the other, lent legitimacy, overriding the gender factor.

In Bangladesh, since the assassination of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, the effective leadership has been rotating between the military, several male leaders, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's daughter Sheikh Hasina Wazed, and Khaleda Zia, widow of President Ziaur Rahman. In recent years these two women have emerged as the most charismatic national leaders. Hasina is now the prime minister and Khaleda the leader of the opposition. Overall, the direct participation of women in politics in Bangladesh is at least in one respect in advance of that elsewhere in South Asia. Sri Lanka and India have no reservations for women in Parliament. Pakistan has a higher proportion of women (21.1% consequent to the 2002 elections), but most of these 72 members were selected indirectly by the elected MPs and only a few were directly elected. In Bangladesh, as from May 2004, the Constitution provides for reservation of 45 seats for women in a Parliament of 345, which works out to 13%. Unlike in Pakistan, these elections to Parliament are based on popular vote from territorial electorates.

In these four countries particular female leaders have been able to inspire and draw widespread support, especially from women voters. Such leaders as Sirimavo Bandaranaike and Chandrika Bandaranaike in Sri Lanka, Indira Gandhi and Sonia Gandhi in India, Fatima Jinnah, Nasim Wali Khan and Benazir Bhutto in Pakistan, and Sheikh Hasina Wazed and Khaleda Zia in Bangladesh derived their charisma, at least in part, from their father, brother or husband. These women

have surely inspired and given confidence to other women and helped to break down gender prejudices. These advances are undoubtedly of significance but not on any transformative scale. None of these leaders appeared to have made a major durable impact on the level of women's representation or on other feminist issues. Curiously, in exceptional cases, feudal succession has gone from women to men (Indira Gandhi to her son Rajiv, and Benazir Bhutto to her husband Zardari), and in one case from mother to daughter (Sirimavo Bandaranaike to Chandrika), but the overriding factor in the succession is feudal. Some of these women have also secured the backing of powerful conservative religious leaders who were also, clearly, influenced by the feudal factor legitimizing a particular female succession rather than any commitment to the emancipation of women.

Even in feudal Europe, legitimacy has occasionally been conferred on a particular woman (e.g. Joan of Arc) to play a leadership role generally denied to women. In modern democracies, the rise of women to top political leadership has been slow and the feudal factor has not played, or seems likely to play, a major role. The sudden emergence of individual women at the political apex has not happened in modern democracies outside Asia. Perhaps, with the progressive modernization and democratization of society and the emancipation of women, such sudden emergence of female national level leaders may cease to occur in Asia, too.

Though from the perspective of undermining prejudices against women holding high office, every opportunity for a

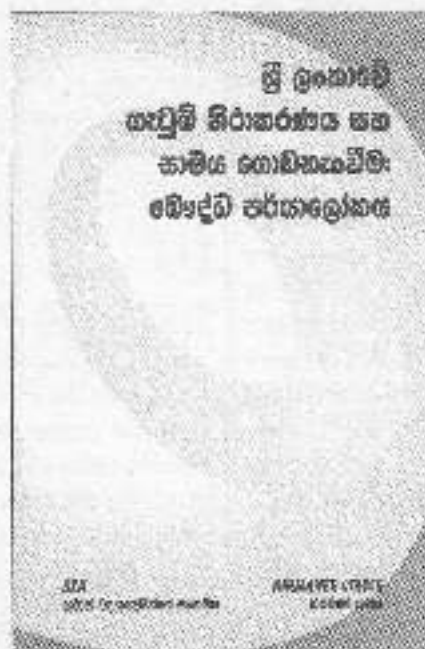
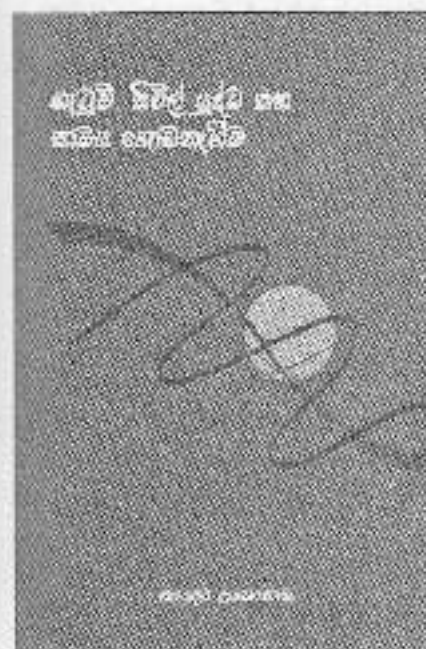
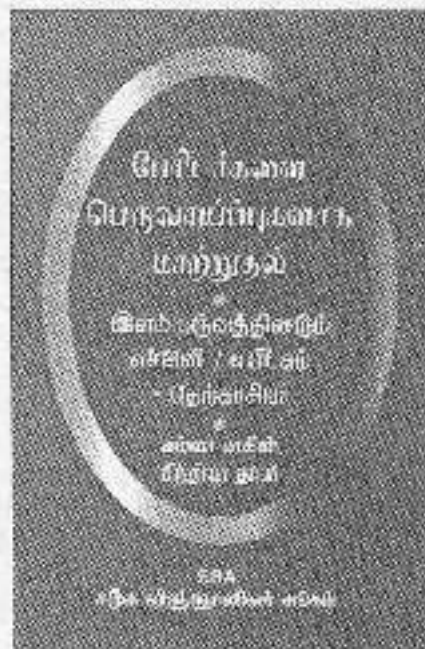
woman to hold high political office may be welcome, we need to be wary of interpreting such opportunities as evidence of emancipation. It would be much more important to broaden the field, e.g. getting more women directly elected to political bodies at all levels from territorial electorates, whether open or reserved, whether on the strength of women's votes or that of all voters in the territory. The emancipation of women cannot rest securely on a feudal base. At least for a limited period (a few decades?) well-designed schemes of reservation could be critically instrumental in advancing the emancipation of women.

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FROM CAGED BIRD TO EMANCIPATED WOMAN

Sarojini Jayawickrama

"Women's Worlds": The McGraw-Hill Anthology of Women's Writings, edited by Robyn Warhol Down et al.

"**W**omen's Worlds" is a compilation of writings in English by women from diverse areas of the world, from different geographical spaces and across time — from the fourteenth century to the present day. Different from traditional women's studies, its focus is not limited to Anglo-American writings. It is a richly textured tapestry of writings from Africa, Asia, Australia, New Zealand, Scotland, Ireland and the Caribbean and of works by writers of mixed heritage — African American, Asian American, Afro Caribbean and Anglo Indian. It features classic as well as exciting new voices from these geographical spaces and diverse cultures. In this aspect it reflects the global spread of English through colonization and emigration and so traces the impact of colonialism and its attendant dispersal of people, not simply from choice but through compulsion — through slavery and the slave trade and through enforced emigration when, for instance, beginning in 1788, British prisoners were transported to penal colonies in Australia.

It does not claim to be a definitive and all comprehensive work. Aware of its inability to unearth every piece of writing from times as far distant from our own as the fourteenth century, it dedicates itself "To all the women writers who are not represented in this volume". Virginia Woolf, writing as late as 1928, could find no evidence of women writers before the eighteenth century. In her seminal work, *A Room of One's Own*, she creates a fictional character — William Shakespeare's "wonderfully gifted sister" Judith who, frustrated in her desire to pursue a literary career by a society who would not tolerate a woman writer, takes her own life at the tender age of seventeen. Some of these pre-eighteenth century writings may have been destroyed, others simply forgotten or not "discovered", lost and uncatalogued in manuscript archives, early book collections and private libraries.

The anthology is structured chronologically, listing authors by their date of birth, and organized more broadly in periodized divisions — the fourteenth to the seventeenth centuries, the eighteenth century, the nineteenth century, and the twentieth century to the present day. Each section is

prefaced by an historical overview, crude and insightful, which helps the reader (the anthology is aimed primarily at students in higher education) to familiarize her self with the cultural milieu of the period and gain a broader grasp of the social, material, cultural and historical context. A timeline pinpoints significant events of the time, historical and literary.

Maps of the world, changing and evolving as people's perception of their place in the world changed, introduce the different sections. It is interesting to note that the map of the world in the 1540 Ptolemy edition of *Geographia Universalis*, which precedes the fourteenth to seventeenth centuries section, depicts only England, France and Ireland. England is pictured on its side, suspended between France which is placed above it—since it was perceived as a threat to English power since a time which predated even the Norman Conquest in 1066 - and Ireland, England's first colony - subdued through sheer force and the imposition of the English language—which is placed below it. This depiction is not of the reality but of a perceived reality. The contraction of the world may be attributed to the fact that these three land masses were all that were known to England at the time. Before exploration and Empire, this was the English-speaking world. It was in the seventeenth century, through the advance of colonialism, that the English language began to spread beyond the British Isles.

The head notes to the selections focus on the lives of women writers, the conditions in which they lived and produced their work, and their reception. These head notes emphasize the material constraints as well as the opportunities that the circumstances of their lives offered these women who had to resist the circumscribed roles that the patriarchal societies in which they lived imposed on them. The century introductions and the head notes reflect the current trends in feminist literary and cultural theory and the teaching experience of the editors, all of whom are university academics.

The unique contextualization of the writings in essays titled "Cultural Coordinates" offers the reader an insight into specific examples of material culture that impinged quite dramatically on women's lives. They illuminate some of the references in the writings which the writer composing her writings for a different readership assumed that her reader

would know. They have since become unfamiliar to the contemporary reader perusing them six hundred years later, over boundaries of time and borders. For instance, what it meant to be dubbed a "scold" in sixteenth and early seventeenth century is discussed. It referred to a woman who verbally resisted her husband's dominance, for which "crime" she was publicly punished in humiliating ways, either by being "cucked" or ducked in a fetid pond to the derisive applause of a jeering crowd, or by having a "scold's bridle" attached to her head. Literature of the time often alluded to the "scold's bridle", which was a veritable instrument of torture that was used to punish women found guilty of verbal or sexual transgression. The accompanying illustrations (79-80) convey a vivid image of the cruelty of the punishment endorsed by the society of the times.

"Cultural Coordinates" sensitizes the reader to links and connections which may not have been perceived. For instance, in reading "The Tea Table" (416), we see the link between the ritual of women sitting round a tea table sipping a cup of tea from a fine bone china cup and the institution of slavery and the slave trade. In a wider sense we see its implications in colonialism. In "Needlework" (39), we see that embroidery practiced by women across all class boundaries was not just an art but a form of control; even the very posture of the women when they sat at their needlework, head bent, eyes lowered on their work, spoke of submissiveness. But conversely, the essay discusses how the art of embroidery was used as a subversive act by women like Mary Queen of Scots, who embroidered a panel of a large tapestry known as the Oxburgh Hanging while being imprisoned in the Tower of London on suspicion of treason. It depicted an emblem and above it a Latin inscription "Virescit Vulnere Virtus" (courage grows strong at a wound). A copy of this emblem found in the possession of Thomas, Duke of Norfolk, was produced at his trial for treason, as evidence of the threat Mary and he posed to Elizabeth I.

In Their Own Words

The anthology represents the articulation in their "own words", in diverse voices, of women's perception of the world in which they live and of their identity in that male dominated world. Their writings express their search for an individual identity and selfhood that was often denied them. Theirs was an identity defined by the men they married or their relationship to men (as wives and daughters). This was particularly so in the fourteenth to the nineteenth centuries when they were assigned the stereotypical role as "the angel in the house", which restricted them to the confines of the

home, limiting their scope of activity to the private domain, the only world they could inhabit, and stifling the possibilities of fulfilling the rich creative potential within them. But this did not necessarily mean that every woman let herself be imprisoned within these narrow confines. Need, or often desire, led them into the outer world to work in fields, in the homes of others, in domestic service, and in shops and factories, to support themselves and their families. Their homes were located not only in England and the United States, but in places as far away from these metropolitan centres as Zimbabwe, the Caribbean, Malaysia, India, Sri Lanka, the Philippines and the islands of the South Pacific.

Transcending the Class Divide

The reader is offered a rich selection of writings not only from different geographical spaces far flung around the globe, but from spaces of "difference" within Great Britain and the United States, from women who live in "a world of difference" (the phrase is Barbara Johnson's), working class women, immigrant women and lesbians, whose writings are not always regarded as belonging to the category of "important" literary works. The selections in the anthology move not only across cultural boundaries but across the class divide. Excerpts from the "Turkish Embassy Letters" of Lady Mary Wortley Montagu (1689-1722), a woman whose life was one of wealth and privilege and who travelled widely accompanying her husband to Turkey when he was appointed his country's ambassador there, are balanced against the perspective on the world of Mary Leapor (1722-46) who laboured in domestic service as a cook's helper:

With low'ring Forehead, and with aching Limbs,
Oppressed with Headache and eternal Whims, (from
"Crumble Hall, 251).

The daughter of a Northamptonshire gardener, she learned to read and write in a free school. Wortley Montagu was self-educated, and like most eighteenth century women of the elite social group to which she belonged, she had access to a private library, in her case her father's remarkable one. Leapor did not have the leisure to write nor were the same facilities available to her, but she "scribbled" while the meat scorched, as one of her employers later complained. She had more time to pursue her interests when, on her mother's death, she returned home to keep house for her father. In her poem "Crumble Hall (251-55), where in emulation of Alexander Pope she writes in heroic couplets, Leapor takes us on a servant's tour of the Great House. With her we climb the steep back stairways and enter the store rooms, attic and kitchen where:

Safely the Mice through yon dark Passage run Where
the dim Windows ne'er admit the Sun. (253)

This was the domain of women like Leapor in domestic service in these Great Houses.

Wentley Montagu transports us in her letters on "A Visit To A Turkish Bath" (240-42) to a world of opulence and wealth, vastly different from Leapor's, to the marbled baths and its sofas, luxuriously covered with cushions and rich carpets where "ladies of quality" attended by their slaves, eased away their cares and the stress of everyday life in the vapours of the steam baths.

Even for the period in which English was spoken only in England by a mere 5-7 million people, despite the difficulties of unearthing these documents, the anthology presents us with a fascinating selection from women writers from different social strata. They include writers not familiar to many of us – nuns like Julian of Norwich (an excerpt from "The Revelation of Divine Love": 24-25) and Margery Kempe (an excerpt from "The Book of Margery Kempe" 29-32), and those from aristocratic circles of monarchs such as Elizabeth I. Two poems by her, "The Dread of Future Foes" and "A Song Made by Her Majesty" (42) are juxtaposed with the writings of Jane Sharp (active 1671), described as "the first English woman to write a book on gynaecology" (an excerpt from "The Midwives Book" 217-19), and "The Ballad which Anne Askew Made and Sang When She Was in Newgate". Anne Askew was imprisoned in the notorious London prison for her religious beliefs, being a Protestant in a country which remained Catholic until the late sixteenth century despite Henry VIII's break with Rome. She was arrested twice and interrogated about her religious beliefs by the King's Council after each arrest. Sentenced to death, she was tortured in the Tower of London before her execution by burning. (36).

Different Genres

The anthology includes not only selections from the traditional literary genres of fiction, poetry and drama but, since women's writing often transcends these boundaries, it also has essays on philosophy and feminist theory; for instance, Mary Wollstonecraft's "A Vindication of the Rights of Women with Strictures on Political and Moral Subjects" (366-82), and the articulation of newer voices like Paula Gunn Allen, whose perspective is Native American, and that of bell hooks (1894-95), whose viewpoint is African American. There are letters and selections from autobiographies that reveal very personal facets of the lives of the writers, the

material conditions of their lives, the laws, the social structure and the norms and conventions that impact on them. The seventeenth century memoir of Lady Anne Halkett, the correspondence of eighteenth century US First Lady, Abigail Adams, the slave narratives of Mary Prince, Harriet Jacobs and Hannah Crafts, and the "Captivity Narrative" of Mary Rowlandson, who was English born but emigrated to the Massachusetts Bay Colony in 1639 and was then captured and kept hostage by an Indian tribe. Her narrative became a bestseller and the literary model for the many captivity narratives that followed. These are some of the memorable writings in the anthology. Coming closer to the present times, there are the memoirs of Jean Rhys (familiar to many of us through her "Wide Sargasso Sea") on her life in the Caribbean, domestic handbooks featuring recipes and household advice from Isabella Beeton (nineteenth century), hymns, both patriotic and devotional, lyrics by blues artistes and the newest genre of women's writing in print, the graphic memoir; a selection from Alison Bechdel's "Fun Home: A Family Tragicomic", a comic book format which is an unusual approach to women's autobiography, suggests the richness, the diversity and the time span of the selections, many of which are published in their totality.

Women: the Dispossessed in Society

The impact of law on the position of women in the fourteenth to the seventeenth centuries is exhaustively discussed in the historical overview (7-13) and the "Cultural Coordinates" essay which precedes this section. The essays discuss the manner in which the law operated in this age to define marriage, making the woman an unequal partner. It is possible only to give a brief sketch of the complex web of laws that governed the lives of women, making her completely dependent on her husband. The doctrine of coverture, which applied to all women whether they belonged to the nobility or the middle or lower classes, asserted that husband and wife were one person at law. It meant that a woman had no legal rights to anything including her own body. Amazingly, six hundred years later, a woman's rights over her own body are still at issue. Reproductive rights and abortion rights are still vigorously debated, the latter being one of the key issues in the recent United States presidential election.

T. E., in "The Lawes Resolution of Women's Rights" (1632), wrote that every woman is an infant, lacking power "even in that which is more her own". In his view a woman hardly had an existence independent of her husband. "A woman" he states in the confident voice of male authority, "glittereth but in the riches of her husband as the moone has no light but in

the sunne's". The infantilization of women has resonances of the colonial strategy of imposing an infantilism on the "native", practiced to exercise continuing control over the inhabitants of a country occupied by the colonizing power; it underlines the link between colonialism and the systems of domination imposed on women. For women in many countries the movement for national independence was synonymous with the struggle for women's rights.

Since the doctrine of coverture that prevailed from the fourteenth to the seventeenth centuries invested the husband with sole rights to his wife's property including her body, there was room for domestic abuse, and there is evidence that wife abuse was prevalent and condoned by society. Virginia Woolf, in *A Room of One's Own*, quotes from Professor Trevelyan's "History of England" where, under the heading "Women", he describes "wife-beating" as "a recognised right of man, and was practised without shame by high as well as low. . . . Coverture was aimed at consolidating property and power and impacted strongly on the kind of marriage girls of marriageable age, particularly from the nobility and the affluent classes, entered into, marriage rarely being based on love, being closer to a business merger. The anthology contains two selections from the seventeenth century diaries of Lady Anne Halkett (97-100) and Mary Boyle Rich (103-10), women who resisted their families' dictates on their choice of marriage partners. To quote Trevelyan again, he speaks of the fate of "the daughter who refused to marry the gentleman of her parent's choice"; she "was liable to be locked up, beaten and flung about the room without any shock being inflicted on public opinion. . . . The effect of the doctrine of coverture was exacerbated by the law of primogeniture which deprived the second son of a family from inheriting property and wealth. Both these women's choice of marriage partners were men who would not have brought financial benefit into the marriage. Aphra Behn in her play "The Rover", published in 1677, like the diarists of the seventeenth century, asserts a woman's right to choose her marriage partner.

The writings of women of this period express a desire for ownership, not only of material things but even of their children; in the event of a husband and wife separating, the woman was denied custody of their children. She was denied even the right to make a will. Even the wages a married woman brought home were the property of her husband. Before 1730 women were expected to write only on theological themes and on their experiences of piety. Any interest in the material world outside the family was viewed with suspicion or even overhostility. A woman who showed such an interest was labelled a whore or even worse (13-14).

Many of the works that express, implicitly or explicitly, a desire for some form of ownership do so through the language of mourning as we can see expressed in some of the early women's writing published in the anthology. Women's desire for power, for property, for access to education, and for the liberty to speak their mind freely, are expressed only on the threshold of loss and death. It is as if a woman is allowed to declare herself as an individual person only at the moment or in anticipation of the moment in which she ceases to exist. It is as if the possibility of approaching death removed the prohibitions on public expression by women (13). Elizabeth Joceline's "The Mother's Legacie to Her Inhome Child"(83-6) and the extract from Dorothy Leigh's legacy book, "The Mother's Blessing" (81-3), are representative of the legacy books written for children to have on a mother's death. Women dying at childbirth being a common occurrence at this time, Joceline and many other mothers had a premonition of their deaths and these legacy books very poignantly express a desire of the women writing to produce something of their own a woman's wish to lay claim in some way to her children (the father's property by law), even from beyond the grave. "These books are a kind of will, a willing or deeply personal intellectual property" (13). The excerpt published is the letter Elizabeth wrote to her husband and attached to her book. It articulates the gendered set of expectations she has for her child.

Politics of Location

The writings featured in the anthology show us that the fictional Judith Shakespeare was not the only woman writing in this early period, although Virginia Woolf's perception was that woman then who was born with the gift of poetry in the sixteenth century was an unhappy woman, a woman at strife against herself. All the conditions of her life, all her own instincts were hostile to the state of mind which is needed to set free whatever is in the brain.

Woolf's passionately held conviction was that the society women lived in, and the material circumstances of her life, were what impacted most strongly on her ability to write. She argues in *A Room of One's Own* (1929) that to be a successful writer, a woman needed her own space, a room of her own, and had to be financially independent and had to have 500 pounds a year (about 40,000 dollars today), an independence that few women had in Woolf's time.

Adrienne Rich, one of the most important writers of the twentieth century, echoes similar sentiments (1558-9). Her belief was that poems and essays (she writes in both genres)

are products of a specific time. She began to date her poems as a way of indicating that there was a "politics of location", that what can be written and is written is very much contingent on the material conditions of the society in which one lives, the "importance not only of a person's personal history but also of her situation within a nation's history and her life experiences — whether of privilege or of oppression" (1191). Diane Wakoski, writing in the late 1980's, who sees herself as a distinctively American poet, says "[I]t is usually written in the context of one's cultural myths, and often with reference to gender and race or ethnic origins" (1674). Through presenting the perceptions of women writers of different ethnic origins, situated in different social and cultural milieus, and writing in different periods of time, the anthology makes manifest that it is the material conditions of everyday life that impacted most strongly on women's ability to release the creative impulse in them and give expression to their concerns, their needs and interests and, furthermore, that there was a "simultaneity of profoundly different lives and modes of expression across women's worlds".

"Women's Worlds", traces the extension of the world of women's writing, the expansion of its horizon as social upheavals changed the configuration of societies through dispersal of people and the shifting of populations through the initiation of the slave trade in 1441, colonization, the movement of people from England and Ireland to North America, armed conflicts like the two world wars of the twentieth century, and the Russian Revolution of 1917, which led to the dwindling of the male population, giving women — though temporarily — a different role to play in society, emerging out of the confines of their homes to work in hospitals and factories. The women's suffragette movement of the nineteenth century, the independence movements in Africa, the Caribbean and Asia and the attendant decolonization, the anti-apartheid movement in South Africa, the civil rights movement and the anti Vietnam war campaigns, are some of the significant movements that had an impact on women's writing, the impetus for women who were moved to write on issues which arose out of these upheavals. By the end of the nineteenth century, English educated Indian born women, such as Pandita Ramabai Saraswati, were writing back to the colonizers, presenting their own perspective on their world (1152).

Breaking Taboos

The anthology traces the trajectory of women's writing through the fourteenth century to the present day where its scope extends to encompass subjects that had been taboo

like rape, incest, and lesbianism. Diane Wakoski gives expression to her perception of American poetry: "American poetry is always about defining oneself individually; claiming one's right to be different and often to break taboos", inflecting this significant aspect of twentieth century writing. Maya Angelou, in her autobiography *I know Why the Caged Bird Sings*, writes of being raped by her mother's boy friend that led her to stop speaking for six years. The excerpt published here (1530) recounts the process of the gradual recovery of her ability to speak.

We can contrast the writings of the seventeenth century diarists Joceline and Leigh with the writings of Margaret Lucas Cavendish (1623-1674) who the editors see as "one of the first writers in English we can call a feminist or protofeminist", to see how far women have travelled on that difficult path of liberation. She protests that we are kept as birds in cages to hop up and down in our houses not suffered to fly abroad. . . we are shut out of all power, and authority by reason we are never employed either in civil or martial affairs, our counsels are despised and laughed at, the best of our actions are trdden down with scorn by the overweening conceit men have of themselves and through a deep despiement of us.

The first woman writer in English to write mainly for publication, she reiterates in her writings the power struggle between men and women. The two selections from her writings included in the anthology attest to her feminism. The reader's attention is focused on the fact that she is a woman and she complains about the way her sex influences her writings and their reception. She was considered eccentric, partly for her taste for extravagant and theatrical dress but more for her intellectual taste and she gained a reputation for madness as she did not conform to the current norms of her society. In an age when women were primarily encouraged to spend their time on the pursuit of piety, Margaret's interest was natural philosophy (science). She read widely on the subject and wrote learned essays on it. In 1655 she presented her 'Philosophical and Physical Opinions' (1101-1102) to the universities of Cambridge and Oxford, hoping for recognition. She gained some of the recognition she sought when, after "fierce debate among its membership," The Royal Society of London invited her to visit that prestigious institution to observe two of the most prominent scientists of the seventeenth century, Robert Boyle and Robert Hooke, conduct their experiments. She addresses her epistle "To the Two Universities," beginning "most famously learned", and concluding with the words: